

architecture, although its structure was different from that of the Egyptians, also had a religious purpose and shared similar functions. Mesopotamian gods were linked with particular cities, and temples in those cities were seen as their houses. Divination—the practice of foretelling the future—was a key part of the religion. The people believed that the gods controlled fate, so divination was used to determine the gods’ intentions, and rituals were performed in an attempt to negotiate a better future. Astrology was a key part of this tradition, and ziggurats—the

tall, stepped towers attached to major temples—were also used as stellar observatories.

In Mesopotamia, the construction of temples was seen as both the king’s privilege and his duty. Mud bricks did not endure long, so temples were often renovated or rebuilt. Royal palaces also became increasingly important there, especially under the powerful Assyrian Empire (see pp.80–81). They were centers not only for the royal court but also for the civil service. With a few exceptions, Mesopotamian kings were considered earthly governors appointed to rule on behalf of the gods, rather than being gods in their own right.

Symbolic riches

Ancient temples were not simply places of worship, but also important centers of administration. Most were part of large tracts of land that provided considerable income and trading power. Before it was destroyed at the

end of the 7th century BCE, the temple of Ashur—the city at Assyria’s ancient heart—was the richest in the world.

The demonstration of power

To build monumental buildings required enormous resources, organization, and labor. These buildings acted as a potent demonstration of the ruler’s power over his subjects, and periods of

CORVÉE Most ancient societies used **corvée labor** to provide a regular supply of **unskilled laborers**. **Corvée laborers** worked on state building projects for a set amount of time each year instead of (or in addition to) paying taxes in the form of money or produce.

prosperity usually show evidence of new construction. When a kingdom lacked central authority, or access to resources, building stopped.

The Egyptian pyramids also provide evidence of ancient methods of construction. Rather than hundreds of thousands of slave laborers or conscripts working seasonally, as had been previously thought, the pyramids were built by 20–25,000 professional craftsmen and corvée laborers who worked year-round. Snefru’s first pyramid was finished in only a few years, so he had first a new palace and then two more pyramids built. The decreasing size of pyramids after the 4th dynasty is probably due to an increase in the number of projects, rather than evidence that the 4th dynasty’s grand projects had bankrupted the kingdom.



Great Ziggurat of Ur
Ziggurats, such as this reconstructed example, were in constant use, with astrologers working all night, every night. They provided an unbroken view across the plain of Mesopotamia.



Choga Zanbil

Mud-brick architecture does not preserve well. No one knows exactly how this ziggurat in Elam (southwest Iran) looked when new.

Monumental construction has continued to the present day all around the world.

MESOAMERICAN ARCHITECTURE

Olmecs 74–75 >> built the first monuments in Mesoamerica in 1000–500 BCE. Successive cultures in the region built **pyramid-shaped temples**. To them, everything possessed a spirit, and mountains were particularly powerful beings, so places of worship were constructed in their image. Pyramid building continued until the **Spanish conquest 230–31 >>**



GREAT PYRAMID, CHICHEN ITZA

THE SEVEN WONDERS OF THE WORLD

A list of the **Seven Wonders of the World**—the most breathtaking achievements of human construction—was publicized in the Greek world from the 2nd century BCE. Included were the **Pharos of Alexandria 97, 118 >>** and the **Pyramids of Giza**—the only wonder surviving today. Also on the list were the **Hanging Gardens of Babylon** in Mesopotamia, described as constructed in tiers, like a ziggurat. No trace of the gardens has yet been uncovered.

LATER MONUMENTS

The Greeks **94–95 >>** and Romans **110–13 >>** continued the monumental tradition. In Europe, the building of stone monuments was revived by the medieval Christian church **196–97 >>**.

IDEA

THE TOWER OF BABEL

The Biblical story of Babel may have begun as a reaction of Jewish exiles in 6th-century BCE Babylon to ziggurats. The Babylonians saw ziggurats, with their stepped levels leading progressively upward, as pathways to the heavens, providing access to astrology. Jewish writers were horrified by the thought of humans climbing to heaven, and wrote that a displeased God disrupted the project by diversifying and confusing the languages of the builders.

